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Maritime Culture: A Sociological Perspective

Lydia Carol-Dekker
Brighton Beach Durban, South Africa

Abstract

The aim of this paper is to analyse and discuss the multifaceted cultures within the merchant navy. It is within this multicultural context that the construction of different cultures occur. If maritime managers are to work successfully with their designated ships, and the seafarers working and living aboard these ships, they need to understand that different cultures exist within the industry. The argument put forward is that maritime management needs the necessary soft skills to develop cultural awareness and become culturally sensitive. The primary source of data was drawn from netography and qualitative methodologies. Secondary data was obtained through maritime dissertations, face-to-face interviews, maritime newspaper articles, maritime journal articles and social media. Two main conclusions emerged: firstly, in maritime scholarship there is a lack of research of the existing maritime cultures; and secondly, few maritime companies are aware of how different cultures are integrated. It is significant that healthy cultures within the merchant marine rely on management's cultural knowledge and their soft skills.

Keywords

maritime culture, maritime organisational culture, ship's culture, safety culture, merchant marine culture

The perception of culture within the shipping industry is confusing, because most seafarers and their associated maritime companies seem to concentrate on a small segment of culture, that being safety culture. However, the industry consists of several cultures, which can be divided into maritime organisational culture, ship's culture, and safety culture. In addition, there is an overarching culture, the merchant marine culture.

Maritime authors mainly focus on cultural diversity and safety culture, both being the breeding grounds for physical and mental problems aboard a ship. Cultural, language

Corresponding author:
Dr Lydia Carol-Dekker, Brighton Beach Durban, Durban, KwaZulu-Natal 4052, South Africa.
Email: lydiacaroldekker@gmail.com

and gender diversity can lead to both miscommunication and misinterpretation of orders which can endanger seafarers' lives and place the ship in danger. Mental problems can be exacerbated by diversity, or multiculturalism on board a ship. Mental problems include isolation, loneliness, bullying, depression, fatigue, to mention a few.[1–4] However, such maritime scholarship does not recognise that culture(s) in the merchant navy is a complex set of systems.

To understand multiculturalism in the merchant navy one must understand culture in general. The first part of this paper will offer some definitions of culture. Thereafter, a discussion is provided of culture within the merchant marine. The paper will then focus on diverse cultures: maritime culture, maritime organisational culture, ship's culture and safety culture. In closing, the author will discuss a new notion, which maritime culture has not considered, that is merchant marine culture, which she argues overarches all other maritime cultures.

Methodology

A wide range of international literature has been consulted to extract the cultural phenomena in the maritime industry. The literature sources are mainly international to ensure that a holistic cultural perspective is presented. In addition, national and international dissertations, e-publications, Netography, face-to-face interviews and a maritime Facebook group – 'Seafarers Forum', an amalgamation of many different maritime social media groups yielded relevant data.

Results

Information gathered from the literature analysis, and the qualitative and netography data, led to the grouping of five categories. These categories were formed because they were cited with greater frequency. As a result, an explanation of the cultural construction within the maritime industry is given. A discussion of culture follows, as it provides a foundation of understanding culture before looking at the different cultural phenomena co-existing in the maritime industry.

1. J. Horck, 'A Mixed Crew Complement: A Maritime Safety Challenge and its Impact on Maritime Industry', *Malmö Studies in Educational Science: Licentiate Dissertation in Education Series*, http://dspace.mah.se/bitstream/handle/2043/5962/Licentiate_Horck.pdf (accessed 25 July 2012).
2. J. Horck, 'Cultural and Gender Diversities Affecting the Ship/Port Interface: Maritime Education and Training Efforts to Bridge Diversity Gaps', *Knowships*, http://www.knowships.org/pdfs/Cultural-Sensitivities-3.pdf (accessed 24 August 2015).
3. E. Kahveci and H. Sampson 'Getting Along at Sea: How to Succeed in Making Multinational Crews Live and Work Together: A Shipboard-Based Study of Mixed-Nationality Crews', *Itfseafarers*, http://www.itfseafarers.org/getting-along.cfm (accessed 11 December 2012).
4. I. Visan and M. Georgescu, 'Steering among a Sea of Islands', *WSEAS*, http://www.wseas.us/e-library/conferences/2012/CambridgeUK/CUMNUPEM/CUMNUPEM-28.pdf (accessed 22 July 2013).

What is culture?

When an individual migrates to another country, a common question they are asked is 'where are you from?' This question allows the individual to self identify their nationality. By answering the question with, 'I am from South Africa', they often satisfy the enquirer. If the enquirer is familiar with the country the individual is from they might want to know which city they live in. The answers proffered serve to classify the individual into categories, such as geographic and social economic, giving the enquirer an idea about the individual's identity, as well as perhaps establishing common ground. When an individual is asked the same question within their own country, they might respond with, 'I am an Afrikaner from KwaZulu-Natal', or 'I am an American from Florida', which might identify their cultural roots and narrow down their identity to the culture they were born into, which is their national and/ethnic culture. We must not forget that social identity cannot develop without the culture(s) to which they belong. But first, to further clarify what culture is, I cite two definitions.

Theorists offer numerous definitions of culture, these reveal that culture as a shared set of values, has a marked impact on people's lives, shapes their lives, and offers them a 'map' of meaning through which they make sense of the world in which they live.

> … culture is a complex set of shared beliefs, values, and concepts which enables a group to make sense of its life and which provides it with directions for how to live.[5]

> … Cultures allow us to build the reality we live in, usually through the meaning we give to symbols, passed down in language … Cultures are shared … they predate those who are brought up in them. Cultures exist both objectively and subjectively: they are objective because they are concerned with material things – they shape styles of dress, food, art, music … and they are subjective because they are concerned with individual interpretations – they exist in the mind and allow us to make sense of the world around us.[6]

These definitions demonstrate that it is not possible to define culture as a single entity. Culture influences who we are, how we behave, what we eat and wear, and thus constantly shape our identity. Culture is dynamic, and it is more than a system, it is a process whereby a person is constructed as a culture or cultures constructs a person's identity. As cultural beings, we are able to interpret our own, and other's actions and reactions in the context within which we live and work. A person cannot 'become' an identity without a culture.[7,6]

To further understand culture, one should understand that culture precedes our birth. We are born into a culture that has existing norms and values, cultural-language and gendered roles that determine appropriate gendered behaviour. It should be noted that the author makes a distinction between language and cultural-language. Language refers to the ability to speak it, enough to be able to communicate. According to the author, cultural-language refers to the symbolic value of that language. To clarify, an individual can

5. B. Fay, *Contemporary Philosophy of Social Science* (Oxford, 2000).
6. W. Kidd and A. Teagle, *Culture and Identity* (New York, 2012).
7. W. Jackson, *Economics, Culture and Social Theory* (Cheltenham, 2009).

speak and understand isiZulu as a language, but this does not mean they necessarily have the ability to understand the symbolic value of the Zulu culture. This is because many words may be 'lost in translation' due to this lack of cultural understanding. One can speak a language but not be part of the culture if one does not have cultural-language.

The culture we are born into is our primary culture. Our family are the people who introduce us to our culture. As we attend school, expand our friendship networks, increase our interaction with peer groups, social groups and perhaps further educational institutions, our informal cultural education increases. It is within our social environment that we notice, both on conscious and subconscious levels, that there are other social groups that are different from us. We start to categorise people into cultural boxes, the 'we group' and the 'other' groups. The 'others'' differences are viewed as different to the 'we' group in a variety of ways. These differences are often related to cultural norms and values. We can socially exclude the 'other' groups by avoiding interaction with them, thus depriving us of learning and perhaps accepting 'other' cultures' differences. This exclusion also prevents us from realising the similarities we have to the 'other'. There is not the scope here to look at the bias and prejudice that this focus on difference leads to.

Culture is transmitted through language.[8] Language within the cultural environment is not only the ability of speaking the lingua, but the ability to understand and communicate within the culture to which we belong. Thus, one can conclude that language is culturally embedded.[9] Consequently, cultural-language socially constructs the member's cultural knowledge of gender, cultural symbolism, body language, rituals, tangible and non-tangible symbolic objects, and coping strategies.[8,10]

The diagram below, by Carol-Dekker, illustrates how culture is transmitted through language and socialization (Figure 1).

Maritime culture

Horck defined maritime culture as being:

> … constructed, flexible, reconstructed, complex, changeable, and identified by great variation and divergent tendencies. The important aspect of culture in the context of the merchant navy is that marine culture carries the same weight as other cultural studies.[1]

Horck explains that the *research* of maritime culture is as important as that of maritime culture.[1] His definition of maritime culture explains that culture is not a fixed entity, but that it is fluid and open for change; thus, it can be culturally reconstructed as the member's world knowledge increases. The vehicle for cultural change is when members of a said culture start to interact with members of other cultures and their world view expands beyond the boundaries of the culture they were born into.

8. V. Burr, *Social Constructionism* (Routledge, 2007).
9. G. Hofstede, G Hofstede and M Minkov, *Cultures and Organizations: Software of the Mind* (New York, 2010).
10. E. Goffman, *Behavior in Public Places: Notes on the Social Organisation of Gatherings* (New York, 1963).

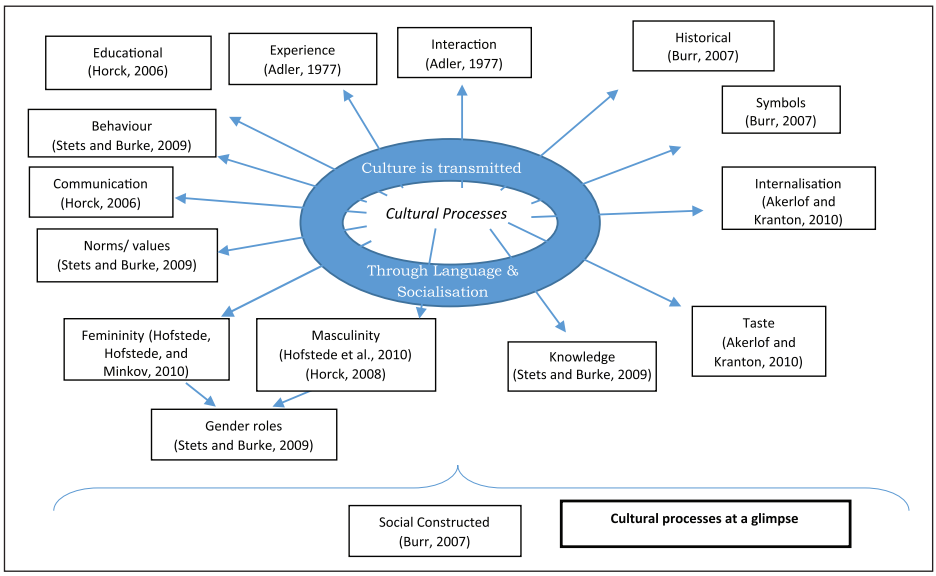

Figure 1. Cultural Processes.

Carol-Dekker argues that culture is deeply embedded in the merchant navy.[11] Therefore, the merchant navy culture formulates the seafarer's identity, the maritime organisational culture, ship's culture and safety culture. The merchant navy is unique in that it can employ seafarers from up to 40 different nationalities. This multicultural work environment includes seafarers from different cultures who speak different cultural-languages, and have different world views.

Adler defined the influence culture has on our minds as:

> Nation, culture, and society exert tremendous influence on each of our lives, structuring our values, engineering our view of the world, and patterning our responses to experience. Human beings cannot hold themselves apart from some form of cultural influence.[13]

Adler furthered his argument by explaining that a person who inhabits a multicultural environment is a person with a 'homeless' mind.[13] The 'homeless mind' is flexible to allow the person to make sense of the multicultural world he finds himself in, making adaptations to this environment easier. However, Adler argues that a 'homeless mind', although flexible, does not allow multiculturalism to become a permanent fixture in his

11. L. Carol-Dekker, 'The Social Construction of the South African Seafarer's Identity and Coping strategies, in the International Merchant Navy' (Unpublished PhD thesis, University of Kwazulu-Natal, 2017).
12. P. Adler, 'Beyond Cultural Identity: Reflections on Multiculturalism', in R. Brislin eds, *Culture Learning* (Hawaii, 1977).
13. K. Gergen, *An Invitation to Social Construction* (London, 2012).

mind.[13] The multicultural world is a temporary culture, whereby his innate culture is so deeply embedded that it has become omnipresent.[13] In other words, even though a person is capable of merging and working in a multicultural environment, the culture they are born into is so deeply embedded that they are not able to shrug it off permanently. Amalgamation into the multicultural work environment is essential, but is not an automatic process as the person entering the multicultural environment needs to consciously decide to interact with their co-workers. This interaction will bring the individuals together as a cohesive unit, which in turn begins the process of constructing a work culture.

Horck explored culture in the merchant navy and highlighted that culture cannot exist without interaction between seafarers.[1] Horck argued that 'in order to belong to a cultural group you need to communicate', with your co-workers in the merchant navy. Communication must intersect with culture, maritime language, gender and race.[1] If communication fails to intersect with one of these diverse segments it inevitably causes a communication breakdown in the others.[8,11,14]

Maritime culture is constructed by observance to policies. A positive maritime culture is dependent on effective communication on board a ship. This in turn can be accomplished by holding regular meetings to ensure that all crew and management are familiar with the goals and job requirements of all parties concerned.[15] Team meetings or 'tool box talks' ensure that all crew members understand what is expected of them about work schedules, procedures, interdepartmental communication and technical operations. By understanding these expectations, the ship and crew safety will increase. Furthermore, including all crew in the daily operations of a ship gives the crew a sense of shared experiences and of belonging (Bhargava, 2013a). A sense of shared experiences and shared knowledge are one of the many components essential in constructing a work environment.

The interchange of procedure knowledge with cultural sensitivity between management and crew can be to the benefit of both parties. The lack thereof can be catastrophic in that miscommunication and misinterpretation of instructions can endanger both the safety of the crew and ship.[11]

Maritime organisational culture

The next identifiable culture in the merchant navy is organisational culture. According to Hill and Jones, organisational culture is:

> The specific collective behaviour of people in an organisation that affects the way individuals and people in an organisation interact with one another and with outside stakeholders.[16]

14. P. Bhargava, 'How Team Meetings Help to Improve Safety and Efficiency of Ships?', *Marine Insight*, http://www.marineinsight.com/misc/marine-safety/how-team-meetings-help-to-improve-safety-and-efficiency-of-ships/ (accessed 30 July 2013).
15. C. W. L. Hill and G. R. Jones, *Strategic Management* (Houghton Mifflin College Division, Boston 2001).
16. J. Aritz and R. Walker, 'Discourse Perspective on Organizational Communication', in A. Jolanta and R. Walker eds, *Discourse Perspectives on Organisational Communication* (Maryland, 2012).

Hill and Jones (2001) treat organisational cultures as those 'values, norms and standards that are part of the collective consciousness of the organisation'.

Maritime organisations are an amalgamation of individuals with different national, cultural and individual identities.[17] When employees' identities fuse with the organisational culture, the influence of this amalgamation is reciprocal and a work culture is constructed.[8,18] The organisational culture regulates the ship and safety culture. Although a ship is only one entity within the maritime organisation, an 'us' and 'them' group can develop between the organisational and ship's culture.[11] The 'us' or 'we' group in this case being a ship culture, and the 'them' or 'other' culture being the maritime organisational culture. Animosity can develop between the ship and organisational culture if the ship's culture holds the view that the organisation does not understand the lived experiences at sea. Seafarers explained this phenomenon as follows:

> The company [organisation] consists of people who never have been to sea, and do not have any knowledge as how it is to work at sea. This is very detrimental to the wellbeing of the seafarers. The companies are run by accountants, who know nothing about the work at sea.[11]

Conflict between the organisational culture and the ship's culture can occur, for example, when there is a breach of the seafarer's privacy, such as when the company 'hack' into the seafarer's email and Facebook accounts. Social media is an extension of a person's social identity where they perform their identity to a selected audience, and an invasion of these personal sites can disrupt this performance and threaten a person's social identity.[19]

The maritime organisation's attitude towards the crew's wellbeing is vital in securing a good relationship between crew and management. Maritime organisations are urged to consider that their multicultural crew's physical, mental and emotional needs are being met. These needs can only be met if the management possess the necessary soft skills to ensure a healthy organisational culture.[20] Horck emphasised that one of these necessary soft skills is cultural awareness.[1]

Soft skills are a necessary ingredient in the development a holistic organisational culture. They are not innate to an individual, and need to be acquired through training. Soft skills' training helps management to understand their multicultural employees' cultural symbols, signs, norms and values.[11,20,21] Shakespeare, Keleher and Moxham summarise

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17. P. Berger and T. Luckmann, 'The Social Construction of Reality: A Treatise in the Sociology of Knowledge' (Penguin Social Sciences, New York, 2011).
18. H. Trotter, 'Sailing Beyond Apartheid: The Social and Political Impact of Seafaring on Coloured South African Sailors', in C. Ray & J. Rich, eds, *Navigating African Maritime History* (Newfoundland, 2010), 189–213.
19. I. Dorsey, *Soft Skills for Hard Times: A Handbook for High Achievers* (Elibris Corporation, Chicago, 2004).
20. A. Kuokkanen, P. Varje and A Väänänen, 'Transformation of the Finnish employee ideal in job advertisements from 1944 to 2009', *Acta Sociologica*, 56, No. 3 (2013), 213–26.
21. P. Shakespeare, P. Keleher and L. Moxham, 'Soft Skills, Hard Skills and Practice Identity', *Open.ac.uk*, http://www.open.ac.uk/opencetl/files/opencetl/file/ecms/web-content/Shakespeare-Keleher-and-Moxham-(2007)-Soft-Skills-Hard-Skills-and-Practice-Identity.pdf (accessed 6 February 2016).

the importance of hard and soft skills by saying that the two cannot be separated; hard skills are the knowledge acquired when one receives the training to do a specific job, while soft skills help a person to execute their job through communication with multicultural employees and co-workers.[21]

The International Maritime Organisation (IMO) overcame this lack of soft skills in 2010 by making the Human Element Leadership and Management (HELM) course a requirement of the International Convention on Standards of Training, Certification and Watchkeeping (STCW) for Seafarers. This course was developed to train officers how to be more culturally aware and how to manage and motivate the multicultural crew under them. The purpose of the HELM course is to ensure that the learner acquires the ability to manage the ship, meet the needs of the crew and promote teamwork. It also enhances understanding of the links between accidents and human elements such as fatigue, stress, lack of communication, and cultural miscommunication and/or misinterpretation, which is common among multicultural staff and crew.[23] The HELM course also alerts management to the importance of social interaction in overcoming the many problems that can arise between multicultural crew and staff.

Ship's Culture

The maritime industry is mostly a multicultural work environment; thus, seafarers are exposed to diverse nationalities, cultures, languages, gender and race. It is within this multicultural environment that a ship's culture is constructed.[11] Land defined a ship's culture as being:

> Based on the shared experience of danger, confined living spaces, in an [traditional] all-male dominated community.[24]

A ship's culture is constructed by the inimitable environment wherein seafarers work, live and socialise.[25] The maritime company's work ethic and policies inevitably influence a ship's culture. Even so, it is the seafarers' daily integration during work hours, social interaction after hours and communication with each other that constructs a ship's culture.[14] A healthy ship's culture is necessary to cultivate a 'home away from home' for

22. D. Crowley, 'Human Element Leadership and Management - Operational Level (HELM-O)', *North Kent.ac.uk*, http://www.northkent.ac.uk/commercial-courses/short-courses/2262/human-element-leadership-and-management–operational-level-helmo (accessed 24 April 2016).
23. I. Land, 'The Many-Tongued Hydra: Sea Talk, Maritime Culture and Atlantic Identities 1700–1850', *American and Comparative Cultures*, 25, No. 3–4 (2002), 412–71.
24. M. Borovnik, 'Seafarers' "Maritime Culture" and the "I-Kiribati way of Life": the Formation of Flexible Identities?', *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography*, 26, No. 2 (2005), 132–50.
25. M. Dickinson, 'Report: Bullying, Discrimination and Harassment survey 2010', Nautilusint.org, http://m.nautilusint.org/media/169246/Bullying-Discrimination-Harassment-survey-2010.pdf (accessed 8 January 2013).
26. M. Dickinson, 'Protect and Respect', https://nautilusint.org/media/169324/Protect-and-Respect-pack-anti-bullying-guide.pdf (accessed 8 January 2013).
27. Sea Health, 'Crisis at Sea: How to Move On'. *Sea Health*, http://www.seahealth.dk/sites/default/files/Crisis%20Management_1.pdf (accessed 20 March 2013).

the seafarer. This gives them a sense of belonging.[26–27] For a healthy ship culture to develop, officers need to acquire the ability to resolve problems and conflicts that might arise among the crew. Some of the problems Dickinson (2011, 2013) looks at pertained to harassment and bullying on board.

The captain influences the construction of the ship's culture. His actions, or inactivity, can cultivate a healthy or unhealthy on board a ship.

> If he [the captain] does not stand up and enforce the company's policies regarding sexual harassment, bullying, and conflict amongst the multicultural crew the ship's culture becomes gender, culturally, and racial/nationality unfriendly and instead of a cohesive ship's culture, 'othering' can occur.[11]

People identify themselves according to their cultural groups. Subcultures develop within a culture, an example of this is found in patriarchal systems within a culture, when women are viewed as the 'other'. Gergen explains that 'othering' occurs when the dominate group view 'others' in a negative light, and therefore they are not part of the 'we' group.[13] He uses the example of how males can view women as the 'other', allowing them to classify themselves as the superior group.

An unhealthy ship culture is constructed the moment that people classify themselves into 'we' or 'us' social groups on board the ship and animosity develops between the 'we' and 'other' groups. This can threaten the said cultural group members' social identities.[8] Hofstede et al. further pointed out that group identity is very important, and that people in different cultural groups will go to extremes to protect their social identities.[8]

It is in an unhealthy ship's cultural environment that bullying, discrimination and harassment can occur due to intolerance between cultural groups.[25-26] This negative workplace culture can be prevented when the captains, officers and maritime companies are supportive, and animosity among the crew can be deterred.[11] According to Hofstede et al., 'people feel related to people whom they share a symbolic group membership, not necessarily a genetic one'. In the maritime context, one can argue that seafarers will construct a positive ship's culture if they feel secure in the ship's cultural context.[8]

Seafarers themselves can resist assimilation into the ship's culture. This lack of assimilation can also occur when the social hierarchy on board the ship is structured in such a way that it is difficult to access, or when the existing ship culture does not accept a newcomer. Failure to integrate into the ship's culture can exacerbate stress in the seafarers.[11] Stress affects the physical and mental behaviour of a seafarer and can cause long term problems.[27] Stress can have a detrimental effect on personal safety, the safety of fellow crew members, and the safety of a ship.[27] Stress is cited as causing up to 90 per cent of all maritime accidents.[28] Stress symptoms can be divided into three categories; physical, mental and behavioural symptoms.[27] Carol-Dekker compiled the table below (Figure 2).[27]

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28. A. M. Rothblum, D. Wheal, S. Withington, S. Shappel, D. Wiegmann, W. Boehm and M. Chaderjian, 'Human Factors in Incident Investigation and Analysis'. In: *2*nd International Workshop on Human Factors in Offshore Operations (HFW2002), Houston, Texas, 8-10 April 2002. London: HSE.

Physical symptoms	Mental symptoms	Behavioural symptoms
Tense muscles in neck, body	Bad mood	Sleeplessness
Frequent colds and flu	Endless worries	Increased intake of alcohol, coffee, and tobacco
Allergies	Irritability/anger	Drug abuse
Raised pulse	Less desire to socialise with others	Anger and aggression
Cardiovascular disease	Loss of/increased appetite	Isolation, lack of emotion
Head/stomach aches	Feeling pressurised at work	Reduced motivation and commitment
Shaking/nervous tic	Difficulty concentrating/ remembering	Reduced performance
Sleeplessness	Depression	Increased sick leave

Figure 2. Physical, mental and behavioural symptoms.

A healthy ship culture is also dependent on a positive relationship between management and seafarers. This relationship can deteriorate if management ignores basic human rights. Various maritime scholars have highlighted problems caused *inter alia* by lack of respect, lack of recreational facilities, lack of internet access to contact family, gossiping, intolerance towards seafarers from other cultures, intimidation, poor command of English and harassment. These issues need to be investigated and dealt with on a continuous basis so that a healthy ship's culture can be maintained and restored.[11,27,29,30]

Safety culture

Raluca defines safety culture as being:

> … the product of individual and group values, attitudes, perceptions, competencies, and patterns of behaviour that determine the commitment and professing of an organisation's health and safety management.[32]

29. P. Belcher, H. Sampson, M. Thomas, M. Zhao, & J. Veiga, *Women Seafarers: Global Employment Policies and Practices* (Geneva, 2003).
30. M. Borovnik, 'Occupational Health and Safety of Merchant Seafarers from Kiribati and Tuvaluapv', *Asia Pacific Viewpoint*, 52, No. 3 (2011).
31. K. Raunek, '12 Main Reasons Seafarers Quit Sea Jobs', *Marine Insight*, http://www.marineinsight.com/marine/life-at-sea/12-main-reasons-seafarers-quit-sea-jobs/ (accessed 11 March 2013).
32. Seafarers' Rights, 'Seafarer Depression: Alone in a Wide, Wide Sea', *Seafarers' Rights*, http://www.seafarersrights.org/2012/05/seafarer-depression-alone-in-a-wide-wide-sea/ (accessed 10 January 2013).

Bhargava asserts that safety is a vital element of a ship's culture as it embraces the physical and mental health of the crew, together with the implementation of measures to safeguard the ship and crew against maritime accidents.[14]

Berg, Storgård, and Lappalainen, and Borovnik, on the other hand, stated that seafaring culture needs to be researched holistically by including the seafarer's cultural orientation and safety culture. Safety culture is predominant aboard a ship.[24,35] To support a safe maritime environment, adherence to policies are imperative. To maintain a healthy ship's safety culture, effective communication is essential in ensuring that individuals adhere to ship safety measures.[13] Effective communication through regular meetings, understanding and adherence to policies are vital. Regular meetings ensure that all the crew on the ship are included; moreover, according to Bhargava, regular meetings have the added advantage in that by including all the crew they build a sense of belonging to the ship, and its safety culture, as they are united by their shared experiences on board.[13]

A healthy ship safety culture is a crucial element of a ship's culture, as it not only regulates the physical and mental health of seafarers, but also safeguards them and the ship against accidents at sea and the safety of all crew members.[14] Accidents at sea usually characterised by a domino effect; for example, the ship might experience technical failure, which can be aggravated by poor communication, the failure to adhere to the safety procedures, and so forth. This can then result in human errors. Human errors in maritime accidents contribute to up to 95 per cent of all accidents at sea.[17,28]

Merchant marine culture

Carol-Dekker (2017) has observed an anomaly in maritime culture, which she describes as 'merchant maritime culture'; that is, a culture that overarches the organisational, ship and safety culture. This is visually represented by Figure 3.

This merchant marine culture model was formulated through using a qualitative platform of focus groups, interviews and Netography during field work.[11] It was during her interviews that she realised that she was not made privy to the lived experiences of the participants, especially the male seafarers. The female seafarers were more open to discuss the day-to-day aspects of working at sea, whereas the male seafarers avoided discussions in this regard. To overcome this obstacle, she had to acknowledge that seafarers, regardless of rank, nationality or the type of ship they worked in, form a cohesive unit. This cohesive unit saw her as an outsider who had no knowledge of the lived experiences of seafarers at sea. The result was that the initial data she gathered lacked depth. But this problem was resolved by inviting a seafarer friend to accompany her to the next round of interviews and to sit in on the focus groups. The guest seafarer was readily accepted by the participant(s) due to his experience of working at sea, which provided the necessary

33. V. Raluca, *Approaches to the Concept of Safety Culture*. Analele Universitii Maritime, Constantia, 2009.
34. P. Bhargava (2013). 'The Problem of Fudging Rest Hours on Ships: Reasons & Solutions, *Marine Insight*, http://www.marineinsight.com/misc/marine-safety/the-problem-of-fudging-rest-hours-on-ships-reasons-solutions (accessed 5 February 2014).
35. N. Berg, J. Storgård and J. Lappalainen, 'The Impact of Ship Crews on Maritime Safety' (Publications of the Centre for Maritime Studies, Turku, 2013).

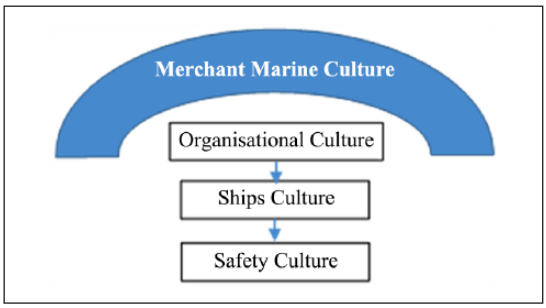

Figure 3. An overarching merchant marine culture.

gateway to the research. Her seafaring friend was unquestionably accepted as a peer as he shared the same seafaring experiences of working and living in and on ships. He spoke the maritime cultural-language.

It was only by inviting her seafarer friend that Carol-Dekker was accepted by the participants and into the conversation among the seafarers.[11] Her friend guided the conversations to allow her to ask the questions pertaining to her research. It is through her experience of being rejected by the seafarers that she formulated a definition of maritime culture. This definition contradicted the definition offered by Land, who argues that maritime culture is 'based on the shared experience of danger, confined living spaces, in an all-male dominated community'.[23] Carol-Dekker acknowledges Land's definition, but contends that his definition is more applicable to a ship's culture than the merchant marine culture.[11,23] Her viewpoint is that the merchant marine culture 'umbrellas and supersedes the organisation, ship, and safety culture'. Thus, Carol-Dekker redefined the merchant navy culture as:

> A group of men or women, who speak the symbolic seafarers' language, and who can narrate their experiences through social interaction regardless of age, culture, gender, race, and/or nationality. This camaraderie is formed by their seafaring experiences. The social cohesion can occur through physical or social interaction or through social media.[11]

Conclusion

The merchant navy is unique in that it is multicultural. Working and living in a multicultural environment is challenging both for workers and for management. However, navigating and integrating oneself into a multicultural environment is essential for the seafarer's physical, emotional and mental health and safety. This integration process is mostly dependent on management, be it the head office or the officers aboard a ship. Thus, it is important for management to understand what culture is, that cultural awareness should be taught, and that they must be familiar with the different cultures in the merchant navy. Cultural awareness is a soft skill all employers and employees need to acquire. Most scholars study just a segment of cultural awareness by highlighting the problems multiculturalism can cause, but neglect to explain the existence of different

cultures in shipboard societies. Culture in the maritime industry must be studied holistically to understand how these various cultures are integrated.

Author biography

Dr Lydia Carol-Dekker is an independent sociology researcher. Her current research interests lie in how the seafarer's social identity is constructed within the maritime industry. Social identity construction research is approached holistically and includes organisational language, cultural-language, and how gender and race are perceived and interpreted within the seafaring context. In addition, Dr Carol-Dekker is interested in the coping mechanisms needed to work in a multicultural environment and how the lack thereof affects the seafarer mentally and physically. Dr Carol-Dekker graduated from the University of KwaZulu-Natal, Durban, South Africa.